CHAPTER 5

The Cosmopolitan Terminus of the Silk Road

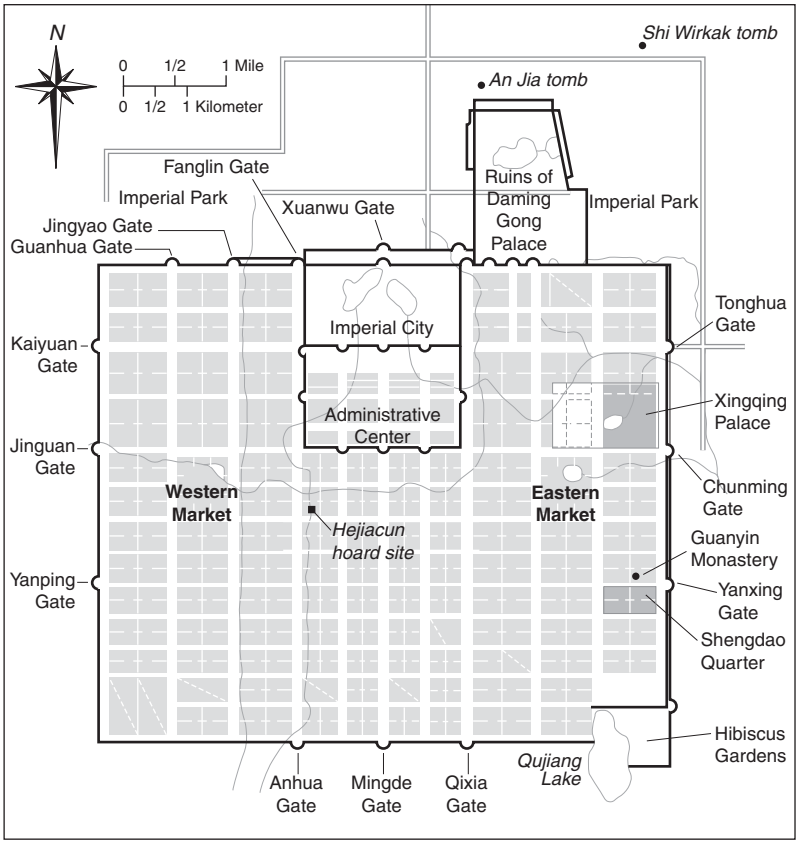
Historic Chang'an, Modern-day Xi'an

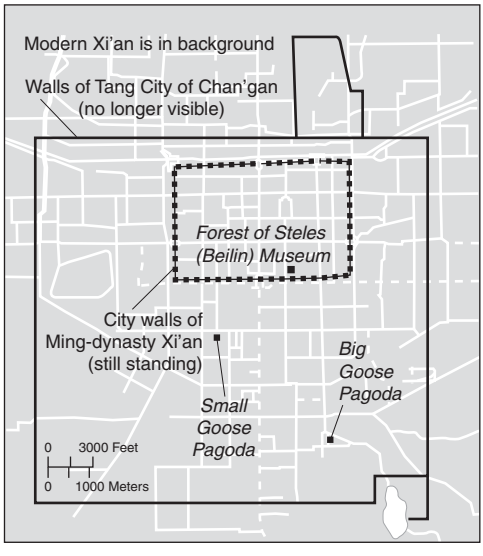
The modern city of Xi'an offers more archeological attractions than any other Chinese destination. The famous terra-cotta warriors are only an hour's drive away, and the Silk Road has left many traces in the city. Many non-Chinese minority peoples inhabit the city, which was similarly diverse during the Tang dynasty when the city was called Chang'an. The elegant figurine on the facing page, who wears an outfit combining Chinese and Sogdian elements, was made in Chang'an. Chang'an was so big that only in the past ten years has modern Xi'an expanded beyond its Tang-dynasty boundaries. With a population of over ten million, it is certainly the largest city in the northwest.

As the city's residents often remind visitors when composing toasts, the city served as the capital of ten dynasties. Seven of these dynasties were short-lived and controlled only the immediate region. Three major dynasties that governed a unified China designated Chang'an as their capital: the Former Han (206 BCE–9 CE), the Sui (589–617), and the Tang (618–907). While a political center, the city also served as a point of departure for those who, like Xuanzang, traveled west on the Silk Road. Before setting off, Xuanzang visited the city's Western Market, home to many Sogdians, because the city's residents could provide him with better advice than anyone else in China.

This inland city was also a starting-off place for those traveling by sea from China to points west. These ocean voyagers proceeded overland (the Yellow River was not navigable) to different ports on the Yangzi River or directly to China's coast. At these ports, they caught boats sailing along the world's most frequented sea route in use before 1500: that linking the Chinese coastal ports with Southeast Asia, India, the Arabian world, and the east African coast.[1]

The city received visitors traveling overland and by sea throughout the first millennium, the peak centuries of Silk Road traffic. After the fall of the Han dynasty in 220 and before the reunification of China by the Sui dynasty in 589, different dynasties led by nomadic peoples ruled the various regions of China, which was never united during that long period. In the north, the Northern Wei





Chang'an, the Tang Capital, Then and Now

- Walled quarter
- Walls
- Gate
- Water course

(386–534) was the longest-lived dynasty, and two brief dynasties, the Northern Qi (550–77) and Northern Zhou (557–81), succeeded it.

Modern Xi'an contains many traces of the past. Chinese law requires that the archeological authorities be notified each time that a bulldozer unearths something ancient, a frequent event in a city like Xi'an, where each year archeologists uncover several hundred tombs from both the Han and Tang dynasties.[2] During the Northern Zhou, a graveyard for high-ranking officials was located in the northern suburbs of modern Xi'an. Some of the newest evidence about overland migration comes from the recent discovery of several tombs of Sogdians who moved to Chang'an and other northern Chinese cities in the late sixth and early seventh centuries.

Two Sogdian tombs in particular have excited much attention since their discovery: that of An Jia (d. 579), unearthed in 2001, and of Shi Wirkak, discovered in 2004. In the fall of 2005 Xi'an archeologists also excavated the tomb of the first Indian buried in the city. His epitaph identified him as a Brahman, meaning someone from India, not necessarily of high caste, with the Chinese name Li Cheng.[3] Sogdian tombs have also been found in other Chinese cities, including Guyuan, Ningxia, and Taiyuan, Shanxi.[4]

These tombs show how immigrants to China, mostly Sogdian, adjusted to—and modified—Chinese cultural practices. While the traditional method of burial in Sogdiana was to expose the bodies of the deceased before placing them in either an ossuary or an aboveground naus structure, the Sogdian tombs found in Xi'an are Chinese in style, with a sloping walkway leading to an underground chamber, and often hold a Chinese-language epitaph giving a brief biography of the deceased.

Yet these tombs retain distinctly Sogdian elements. In place of Chinese coffins, the Sogdian tombs contain either a stone bedlike platform or a miniature stone house. In some cases the remains of the dead were placed on the platform or inside the house, but in others—most notably that of An Jia—they were not.[5] Like ossuaries, the stone houses are decorated on the outside; in contrast, the stone beds have partitions with decorations facing in, as if an ossuary has been "turned inside out."[6] Unlike ossuaries, the stone beds show scenes from the life of the deceased, never the subject of traditional Sogdian ossuary art. The extremely realistic scenes clearly draw on the life experiences of the deceased; they may depict this world or possibly the next.

Named one of the top ten archeological discoveries of 2001, the tomb of An Jia is the only tomb of a Sogdian that had not been previously disturbed when archeologists uncovered it. The vast majority of tombs in China have been opened previously, often multiple times, by grave robbers. An Jia's tomb had a sloping walkway 9 yards (8.1 m) long leading to a door (see color plate 15).

Outside the door was an epitaph for the deceased. Typical of Chinese epitaphs, the text was carved on a low, square base and then covered with a lid, both made of stone. According to Chinese burial practices, An Jia's remains should have been placed in a coffin that rested on top of this stone bed. But the bones were scattered outside the tomb door on the ground, not on the stone bed inside where the Chinese would have placed them—a practice that has defied all explanation, since neither Zoroastrian nor Confucian custom sanctioned such a burial. Everything near the epitaph, including the walls, had smoke marks, as if a fire had occurred at some point.[7]

An Jia, his epitaph reports, was descended from a Sogdian family from Bukhara (in modern Uzbekistan) who had migrated to Liangzhou, what is now Wuwei, the important Gansu town on the road between Chang'an and Dunhuang where Xuanzang also stopped.[8] An Jia was born in 537 to a Sogdian father and probably a Chinese mother from a local Wuwei family.[9] The epitaph claims that his father held two government positions, one in Sichuan, but this seems unlikely given the distance from Sichuan to Wuwei; much more likely, these were honorary positions granted to the father posthumously because of his son's success.[10] An Jia was indeed successful. First serving as sabao in Tongzhou (modern-day Dali, Shaanxi, north of Xi'an), he was given the highest rank a sabao could achieve.[11]

Starting in the Northern Wei dynasty (386–534) dynasties in central China began to appoint headmen for the Sogdian communities, and they adopted the originally foreign word for the position in the Chinese bureaucracy. As a result, sabao took on a new meaning: an official appointed by the Chinese to administer the residents of a foreign community. An Jia received such an appointment under the Northern Zhou, the dynasty in power in Chang'an before his death at the age of sixty-two in 579. An Jia's tomb combines Chinese and Sogdian motifs. The painting above the door shows a Zoroastrian fire altar on a table borne by three camels, an attribute of the Sogdian God of Victory.[12]

The funeral chamber measured 12 feet (3.66 m) square, 10.83 feet (3.3 m) tall, and held the stone funeral platform with stone panels on the sides and along the back. The craftsmen who made them first carved shallow reliefs into the stone and then painted the figures, buildings, and trees with red, black, and white pigments and filled in the background with gold paint. There are twelve scenes in all (three each on the left and right sides, six at the back).[13] On the center of the back wall, a plump An Jia appears seated next to a woman, probably his wife, wearing Chinese clothes in a Chinese-style building with a bridge in front. The Sogdian funeral beds and houses found in China almost always depict the Sogdian swirl, a dance performed by both



PLATE 1. DRIED SILK FLOWERS FROM THE ASTANA GRAVEYARD, TURFAN
Excavated from a tomb in 1972, these brightly colored artificial silk flowers, 12.6 inches (32 cm) high, testify to the extraordinary conditions of preservation at the oasis of Turfan, Xinjiang, in northwestern China. With less than an inch (2.5 cm) of rain each year, the dry soil preserves many items that survive nowhere else in China and in only a few places in the world. Archeologists found a few strands of hair among the stems, suggesting that the flowers were part of a headdress worn by a dancer welcoming the spring in the 600s or 700s CE.

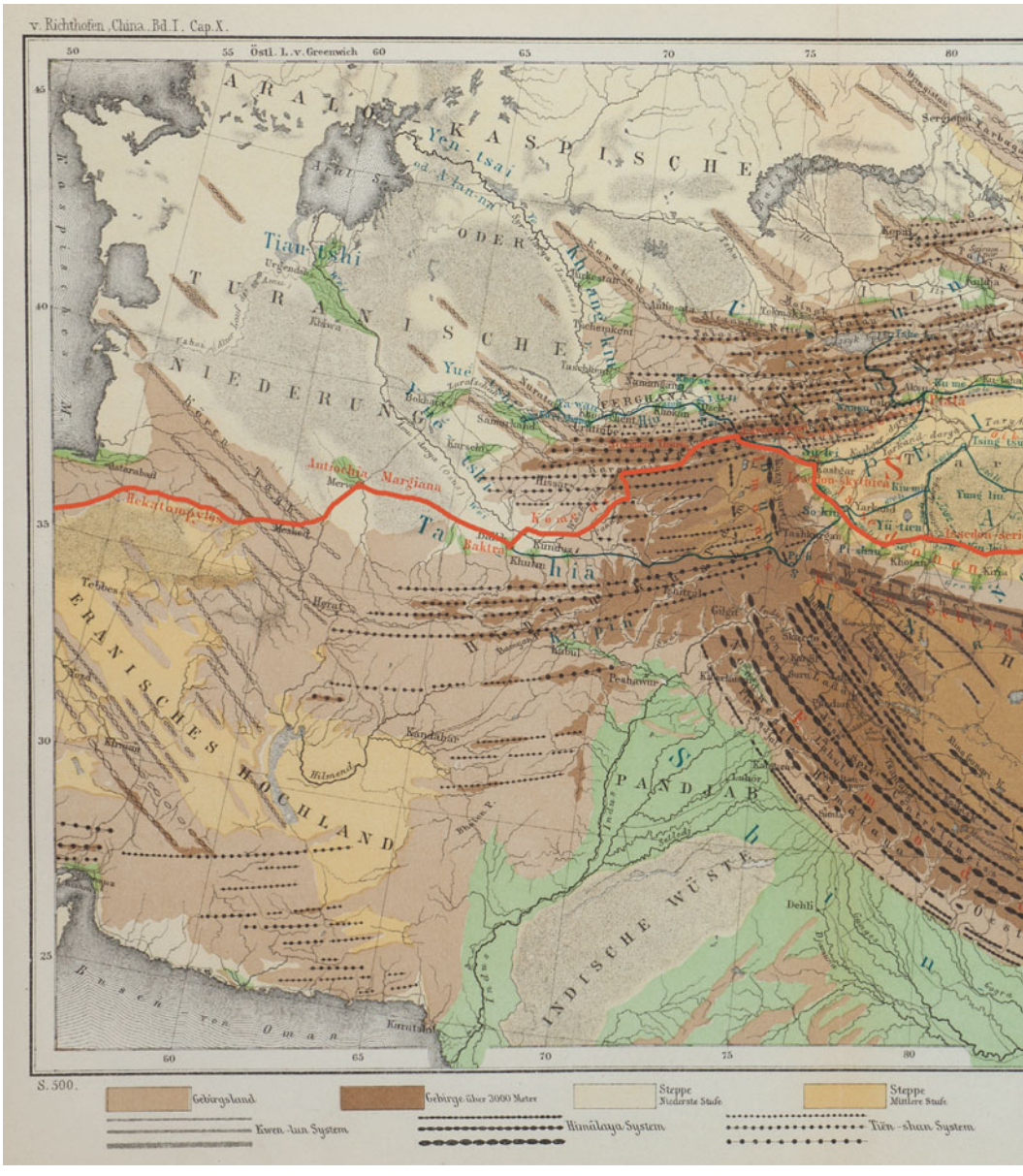


PLATE 2–3. THE FIRST MAP OF THE SILK ROAD, 1877

The German geographer Ferdinand von Richthofen coined the term "Silk Road" with the publication of this map. An orange line, highlighted here, marks the Silk Road. Charged with finding the ideal railroad route from Germany to China, von Richthofen conceived of the ancient trade route as a single line.

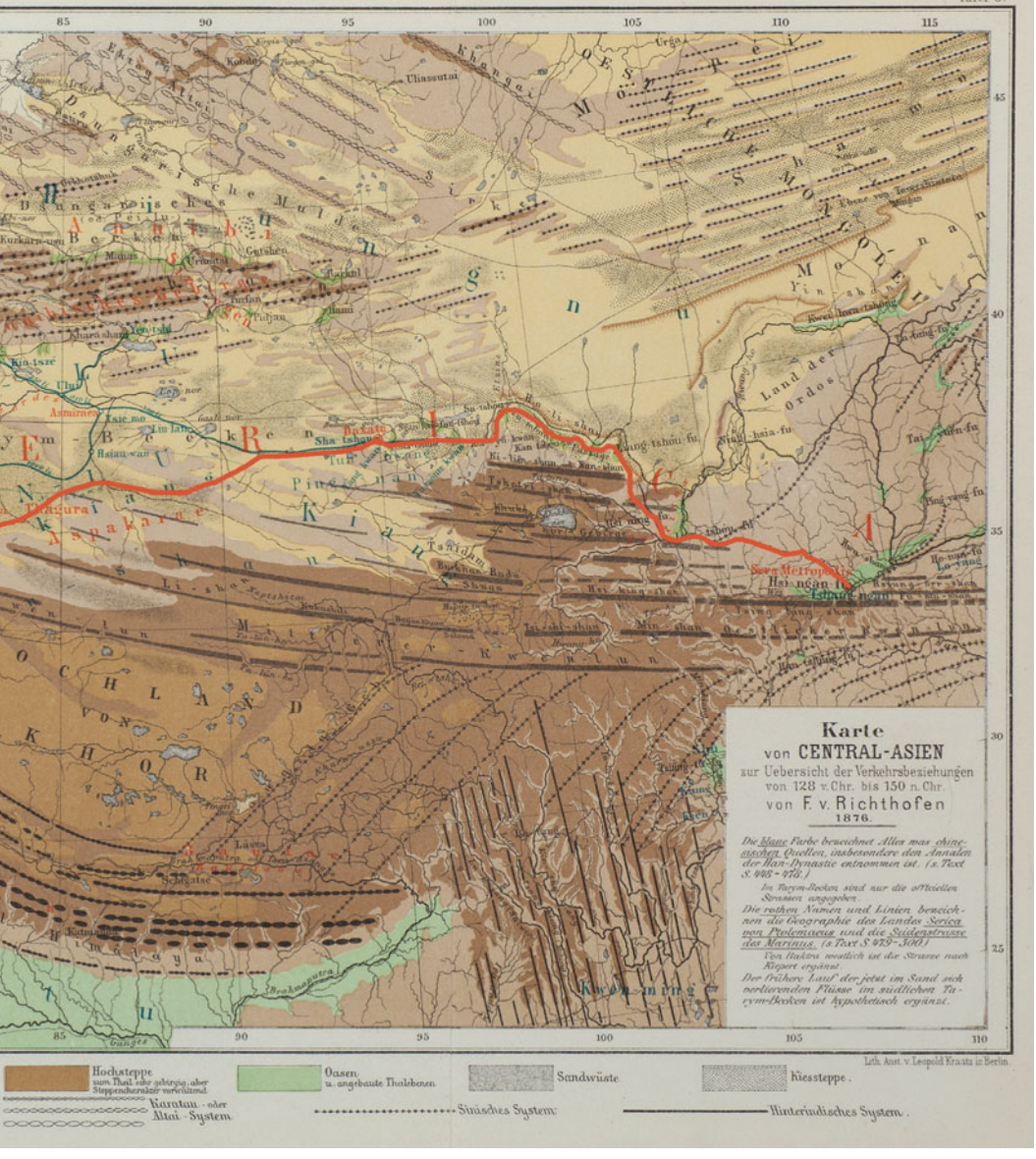

Karte
von CENTRAL-ASIEN
zur Uebersicht der Verkehrsbeziehungen
von 128 v. Chr. bis 150 n. Chr.
von F. v. Richthofen
1876.
Die blaue Farbe bezeichnet Alles was chinesischen Quellen, insbesondere den Annalen der Han-Dynastie entnommen ist. (s. Text S. 905 - 970.)
Im Tarym-Becken sind nur die officiellen Strassen angegeben.
Die rothen Namen und Linien bezeichnen die Geographie des Landes Serica von Ptolemaeus und die Seidenstrasse des Marinus. (s. Text S. 939 - 1001)
Von Bakira westlich ist die Strasse nach Alexert ergänzt.
Der frühere Lauf der jetzt im Sand sich verlierenden Flüsse im südlichen Tarym-Becken ist hypothetisch ergänzt.
Hochsteppe zum Theil sehr gebirgig, aber Steppencharakter vorherrschend.
Oasen u. angebaute Thalebenen.
Sandwüste.
Kiessteppe.
Karakorum- oder Altai-System.
Sinisches System.
Hinterindisches System.
Lith. Anst. v. Leopold Kraatz in Berlin.



PLATE 4A. IMITATION ROMAN COIN USED AS A BURIAL OFFERING
Contrary to the popular view that the Silk Road trade linked Han-dynasty China with Rome, the earliest Roman coins found in China date to the 500s CE, long after Emperor Constantine moved the capital from Rome to Byzantium in 330 CE. To date fewer than fifty gold Roman coins have surfaced in all of China, and many are imitations. This coin, with a diameter of .63 inches (1.6 cm) and weighing .03 ounces (.85 grams), is stamped from a sheet of gold and has a raised front and a concave back like a bottle cap. Genuine gold solidus coins weighed more than five times as much. The Chinese used gold coins like this as protective talismans, not as money. © The Trustees of the British Museum.



PLATE 4B. GENUINE SASANIAN SILVER COIN FROM THE ASTANA GRAVEYARD, TURFAN
Starting in the late 500s and continuing into the 600s CE, the residents of the northwest frequently made loans and purchases using silver coins minted by the Sasanian Empire of Iran (224–651 CE). This example, with a diameter of 1.22 inches (3.1 cm) and weighing .15 ounces (4.28 grams), shows the Sasanian emperor Khusraw II (reigned 591–628), wearing his identifying winged crown on the face and a Zoroastrian fire altar flanked by two attendants on the back. More than a thousand such coins have surfaced in northwest China, testifying to their circulation all the way from the Sasanian capital of Ctesiphon (near modern Baghdad) to the Chinese capital of Chang'an. © The Trustees of the British Museum.



PLATE 5A. SILK AS CURRENCY

Before it snapped in half, this bolt of silk, from the third or fourth century CE, measured 20 inches (.50 m) in length and was used to pay the expenses of Chinese soldiers stationed in the garrison in Loulan. A bolt of silk weighed much less than its equivalent in coins and was easier to ship overland. Much of the silk used on the Silk Road functioned as currency, not as a luxury good, which is why this bolt is a plain basketweave (one thread over, one thread under) with no design. This is the only surviving example of currency silk from the third and fourth centuries. © The Trustees of the British Museum.



PLATE 5B. ROMAN-STYLE WINGED FIGURE MOTIF FROM MIRAN

In Rome, the god Eros was often depicted as a handsome young man with wings. This figure, though, is one of sixteen Aurel Stein found in a Buddhist context at Miran, a site lying between Niya and Loulan. Artistic motifs like this were easily transported along the Silk Road, whether made by live craftsmen traveling far from home or copied from sketchbooks.



PLATE 6. NIYA'S ANCIENT BUDDHIST STUPA

After 1700 years, Niya's stupa, standing some twenty-three feet (7 m) tall, is the site's major landmark. Worn by the centuries, its outer layer has been stripped away, revealing the bricks underneath. Even when Aurel Stein arrived on January 28, 1901, looters had already forced open the repository at the base and removed the relics of the Buddha stored there. The rest of the site lay buried under the sands, where Stein found over one hundred dwellings and more than a thousand wooden slips with writing on them.



PLATE 7. JOINT BURIAL ON THE SILK ROAD
This Niya coffin, measuring 7 feet 6 inches (230 cm) in length, holds a couple: the man on the left, his wife on the right. Knife wounds on his neck point to the probable cause of death, but his wife's corpse is unmarked, indicating that she was most likely killed by suffocation so that they could be buried together. With a total of thirty-seven richly woven silks dating to the third or fourth century CE, the tomb is one of the richest textile finds at any Silk Road site. Some of the textiles have the Chinese characters for "king" and "lord" in their designs, a sign that they were gifts to local rulers from dynasties based in China. Courtesy of Wang Binghua.



PLATE 8. THE HEIGHT OF SILK ROAD FASHION

Crafted in the seventh century in the Tang capital of Chang'an, this Chinese beauty has typical Tang-dynasty hair and makeup, including flowers painted above her eyebrows. Her outfit combines the best of Central Asian fashion: a shirt with facing birds surrounded by pearls—and Chinese: a shawl and a striped skirt with a gauze overskirt. When this figurine was on display at the Metropolitan Museum of Art, the staff nicknamed her "Tang Barbie" because she was the same height (11.6 inches, or 29.5 cm) as the doll and every bit as fashionable. Courtesy of Xinjiang Museum.



PLATE 9. BUDDHIST CAVES AT BEZEKLIK

This once-remote Buddhist retreat is now a major tourist destination for those visiting Turfan. The Bezeklik Caves, like almost all Buddhist cave sites in Xinjiang, were dug into the fragile conglomerate of the hillside overlooking a river valley. Many of the original wall paintings in the Buddhist caves (on left) are now on display in Berlin where they were taken early in the twentieth century. Still, one priceless Manichaean mural remains on site under lock and key, and few tourists manage to see it. The brick house for drying raisins (lower center) is a typical sight in the Turfan countryside. Author photo.



PLATE 10. SVEN HEDIN TRAVELS ACROSS THE TAKLAMAKAN DESERT BY BOAT

Most riverbeds in the Taklamakan Desert today are bone dry, but in 1899 the Swedish explorer Sven Hedin used this 38-foot (12 m) boat to explore the waterways of the region. Starting north of Yarkand, he traveled 900 miles (1500 km) in eighty-two days and stopped three days' journey away from Korla because of large blocks of floating river ice. Hedin's watercolor shows that the deck was large enough for his tent, a small wooden building that served as his darkroom, and a clay firepit where his men prepared meals.



PLATE 11A. NEW LIGHT ON A LOST RELIGION

Before the discovery of the Turfan documents, the little we knew of Manichaeism came from Augustine's critical description in his *Confessions*. Manichaeism was an Iranian religion founded by the prophet Mani (ca. 210–276) who told of the struggle between light and dark. This brilliantly colored detail from an eighth- or ninth-century book found at Turfan shows the Bema festival, the high point of the Manichaean ritual year. It depicts the transformative process that lies at the heart of Manichaean doctrine—lay people offer melons, grapes, and loaves of bread shaped like the sun and moon, to the "elect" (clergy), who eat the food and so transform it into light particles. When the ruler of the Uighurs converted to Manichaeism in 762, he became the only ruler in world history to name Manichaeism his official state religion. Bildarchiv Preussischer Kulturbesitz/ Art Resource, NY.



PLATE 11B. PROCESSION OF AMBASSADORS FROM SAMARKAND

Dating to the mid-600s CE, this wall painting from the Afrasiab site in Samarkand shows three envoys bearing gifts for the ruler of Samarkand, then the center of Sogdiana, the Sogdian homeland. These three ambassadors from nearby kingdoms, each wearing a beautifully patterned robe, are among over forty figures—Turks, Chinese, Koreans, and other Sogdians—who illustrate the range of the world's cultures known to the Sogdians and document the importance of envoys in Silk Road exchanges. Courtesy of François Ory.

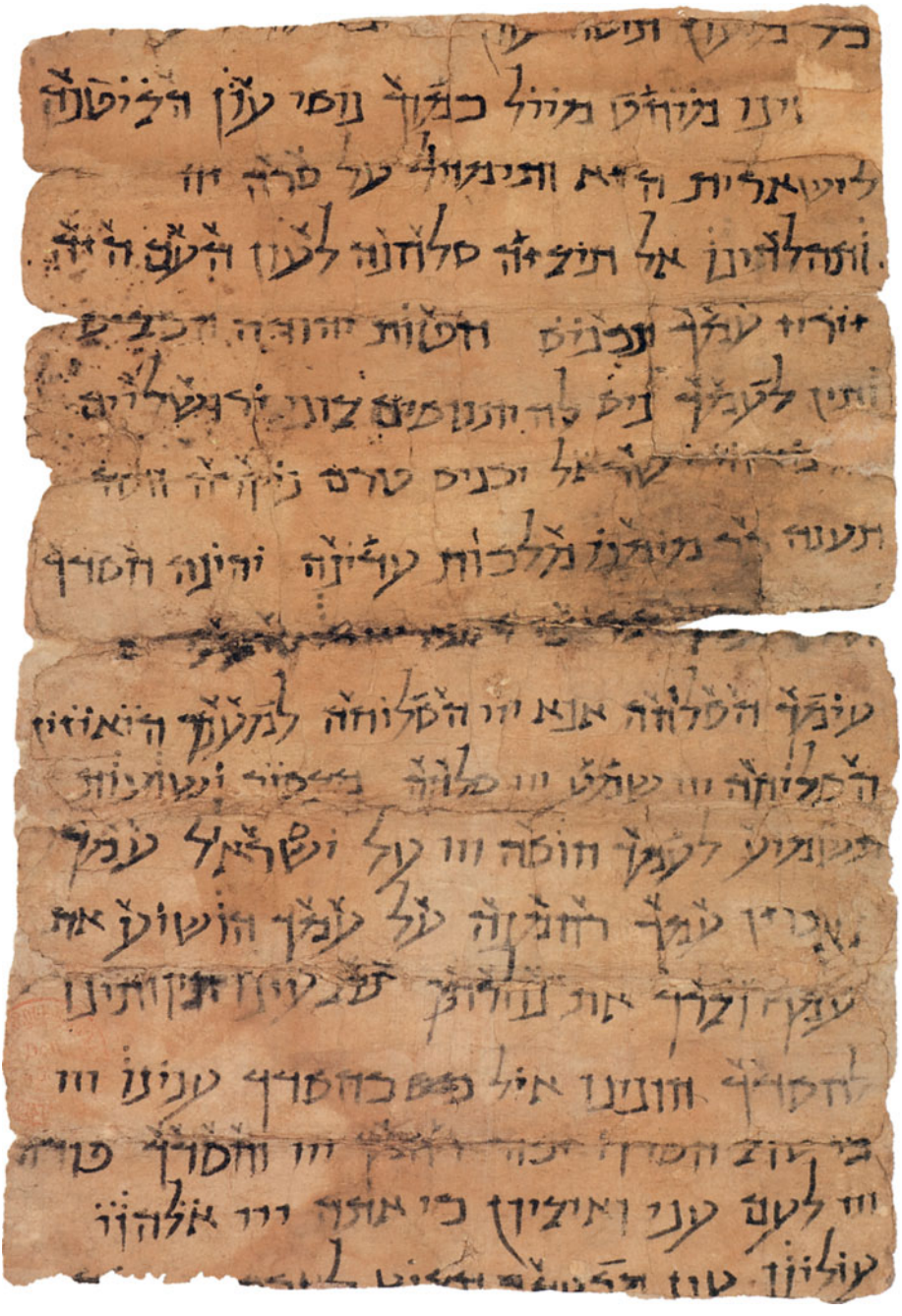


PLATE 12. HEBREW PRAYER FOUND IN THE LIBRARY CAVE AT DUNHUANG
The library cave at Dunhuang contained some forty thousand documents, the lion's share in Chinese and Tibetan. The materials in other languages—Sanskrit, Sogdian, Uighur, Khotanese, and Hebrew—intrigue scholars because they document the presence of other peoples about whom we would otherwise know nothing. This, the sole Hebrew document in the cave, contains an eighteen-line prayer composed of individual lines from the Psalms. Folded over several times and placed in a pouch, it most likely served as a protective talisman carried to China from Babylon. Courtesy of Bibliothèque Nationale de France.



PLATE 13. WOOLEN PANT LEG FROM KHOTAN

This woolen trouser leg was woven locally but features a classical Greek centaur with a warrior shown below. Found at the Shanpula site outside Khotan, these motifs traveled first with Alexander the Great's army to northern Afghanistan and Pakistan and from there to northwestern China. The centaur's cape and the flower/diamond motif on the warrior's lapel are central Asian modifications to the original motifs. The exact date of the pantleg from this heavily looted site is unknown, but Shanpula contains materials from the third century BCE to the fourth century CE.



PLATE 14. SILK ROAD DANCE PARTY FROM THE AN JIA TOMB, XI'AN

The swirl dance, introduced by the Sogdians, was performed all along the Silk Road by men and women alike and described by contemporaries as fast-paced and exciting, This painted stone panel comes from a funerary couch in the tomb of a Sogdian headman in Xi'an who died in 579 CE. This is one of twelve different panels containing shallow reliefs painted in red, black, and white on a gold background; all show different scenes from the deceased headman's life, offering an unparalleled glimpse of Sogdian life in China. Cultural Relics Publishing House.



PLATE 15. ZOROASTRIAN ART FROM THE AN JIA TOMB

The Sogdians formed the largest non-Chinese community in China between 500 and 800 CE. This is the tomb of a Sogdian with a typical Chinese stone tomb entranceway modeled after Chinese homes, but with Zoroastrian art above the doorway. The painting depicts two priests flanking a Zoroastrian fire altar. Curiously the bones of the deceased were placed outside the door, not inside the tomb on a funerary couch as was customary for Chinese at the time. Cultural Relics Publishing House.



PLATE 16A. THE TOMB OF XINJIANG'S FIRST ISLAMIC RULER

This tomb-shrine of the first Karakhanid king to convert to Islam, Sultan Sutuq Bugrakhan, is in the city of Atush, some 28 miles, or 45 km, northeast of Kashgar, in western Xinjiang close to the Kyrgyzstan border. This mazar tomb is among the most venerated sites in Xinjiang, but attendance has declined since a Beijing-based tourism company renovated the site and started charging each visitor an admission fee. Courtesy of Mathew Andrews.



PLATE 16B. WOMAN PRAYING AT THE TOMB OF IMAM MUSAKAZIM

Here a woman kneels in prayer before the tomb of the imam at the Musakazim Mazar, outside Khotan. Offerings on the tomb include sheep skins and multicolored flags with quotations from the Quran. In Khotan, where the armies of the Muslim Karakhanids defeated the king's armies in 1006—beginning the Islamification of Xinjiang—visitors frequently hang animal carcasses stuffed with straw or a flag on a pole above the grave of the deceased. Courtesy of Mathew Andrews.



THE CHINESE TOMB OF A SOGDIAN HEADMAN

The lintel above the doorway to An Jia's tomb skillfully integrates Chinese and Sogdian motifs. A priest-bird with a man's head and torso but a bird's legs and distinct claws stands upright. Wearing a padam face mask, he tends the table bearing bowls and vases with flowers. He represents the Zoroastrian god Srosh, associated with the rooster, who helps the soul cross the bridge from this world to the next and who also serves as a judge in the next world. Above the priest-bird floats a Chinese-style musician surrounded by clouds. The figure on the lower right, who wears a white cap and has a pronounced mustache, is the deceased sabao, An Jia, himself. Cultural Relics Publishing House.

men and women at parties. An Jia's funeral bed depicts the dance three times (see color plate 14).

The panels from An Jia's tomb show little, if any, mercantile activity. Camels bearing goods appear on one of the panels at the back, but the context seems more diplomatic than mercantile. On the same panel, An Jia appears to be conversing with a Turkish leader in his tent.[14] If the camels are indeed carrying trade goods, then these are gifts to be exchanged following the completion of negotiations, a practice that accords with the envoy-dominated trade described in earlier chapters, most notably in the portrayal of emissaries and the gifts they bear in the Afrasiab palace of Samarkand.

A second Sogdian tomb, found 1.4 miles (2.2 km) east of An Jia's tomb in 2003, offers fascinating parallels.[15] The deceased was named Wirkak, a Sogdian name derived from the word for "wolf," and his Chinese family name was Shi; the space for his Chinese given name was left blank, so it is unknown. Like An Jia's tomb, Wirkak's tomb had a Chinese-style sloping walkway leading to the tomb chamber. Whereas An Jia had a stone bed, Wirkak had a stone house 8 feet

(2.46 m) long, 5.1 feet (1.55 m) wide, and 5.18 feet (1.58 m) high with different scenes on the outside walls. Sand had filled the tomb, and archeologists found only this stone house, with a broken roof, inside. There were no other grave goods.

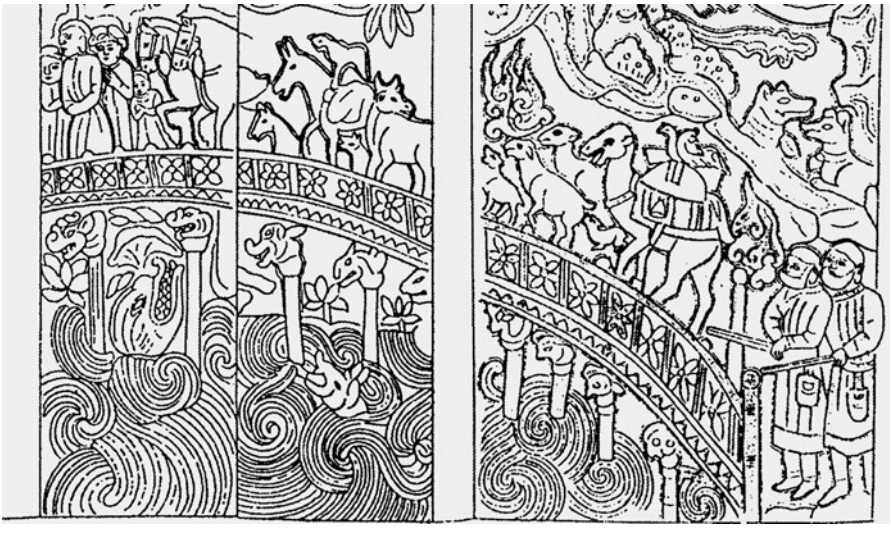
Shi Wirkak's epitaph was in an unusual position above the door of the stone house. Even more unusual, his epitaph had two versions: one in Sogdian on the right, and one in Chinese on the left.[16] The two texts overlap in their account of the facts of Shi Wirkak's life but are not translations of the same text. The scribe(s) who wrote the texts had a weak command of both languages. The two texts concur that Wirkak died in 579, the same year as his wife; had three sons; and served as a sabao in Wuwei, Gansu, where An Jia had also been a sabao. The Sogdian text concludes: "This tomb [i.e. god-house] made of stone was constructed by Vreshmanvandak, Zhematvandak, and Protvantak [or Parotvandak] for the sake of their father and mother in the suitable place," an indication that the term "god-house" must have referred to the house-shaped sarcophagus placed in the tomb.[17]

The stone house had a roof and a base, and the front had two doors and two windows. Bird-priests, similar to those above the door of An Jia's tomb, tend fires beneath the windows, and many elements on the stone house deeply resemble motifs from the An Jia tomb: a banquet, hunting scenes, the deceased inside a tent talking with someone of a different ethnicity. Some of the images are downright puzzling: who, for example, is the ascetic in the cave on the left edge of the northern side? Laozi? A Brahman? Given the openness of the Sogdians to deities from other religious systems, they may never be identified.

The eastern side of the stone house portrays the progress of the soul of the deceased over the Chinwad Bridge. This arresting scene is much more detailed than any portrayal of Zoroastrian beliefs about the fate of the dead from either Sogdiana or the heartland of Zoroastrianism in Iran.

Every motif—the winged, crowned horses, the winged musicians, the crowned human figures with streamers flying behind (a time-honored way of portraying monarchs in Iranian art)—suggests that Wirkak and his wife are about to enter paradise. The identification of the different elements in this scene rests on parallels between the carvings on the stone sarcophagus and Zoroastrian texts, preserved in their ninth-century versions, indicating close familiarity with these religious texts among Sogdians resident in China in the late sixth century—an important finding, since no Zoroastrian texts have surfaced in China to date.[18]

Both An Jia and Shi Wirkak died in 579, in the closing years of the Northern Zhou dynasty, a time of rapid political change. The ruler of the Northern Zhou arranged for his heir to marry the daughter of one of his generals in 578. That



THE PERILOUS CROSSING TO THE NEXT WORLD

This scene comes from a stone house buried in the tomb of Shi Wirkak. On the lower right, two human Zoroastrian priests wearing padam face masks stand facing a bridge. There they conduct the ceremony that sends the souls of the dead off to the next world. On the left, Wirkak and his wife lead a procession including two children (did they predecease their parents?), animals, two horses, and a camel bearing goods across the bridge. Significantly, Wirkak and his wife have made it safely past the monster with ominously bared teeth waiting in the water below. According to Zoroastrian teachings, only those who have told the truth and behaved righteously can cross to the other side of the bridge unharmed; those who have not plunge to their death below as the bridge narrows to razor-width. Courtesy of Yang Junkai.

heir succeeded to the throne in 581 but died soon after, leaving a boy on the throne. At first, the boy's maternal grandfather assumed the position of regent, but in the same year he seized power and founded the Sui dynasty. For the next eight years his armies campaigned all over China, gradually gaining territory, until in 589 he reunified the empire.

The original capital of the Sui dynasty lay in Yangzhou, near the coast of central China, but in 582 the Sui founder relocated his capital to Chang'an, the capital of many earlier and powerful dynasties. He built an entirely new and formally planned city on a site south and east of the city's capital during the Northern Zhou (which was located on the same site as the Han-dynasty capital). The Sui founder ruled for nearly thirty years before dying a natural death in 604. His son succeeded him and led his armies on a series of military campaigns in Korea, which he never succeeded in conquering. The Chinese suffered massive losses, prompting a general to overthrow the emperor and establish the Tang dynasty in 618.[19] Under the Tang, the capital remained at Chang'an except for brief intervals.

When the new city was completed, its 5 yard (4.6 m) high walls ran 5.92 miles (9.5 km) east to west and 5.27 miles (8.4 km) north to south, enclosing a rectangular area of some 31 square miles (80 sq km). Broad main avenues divided the city; the widest was 500 feet (155 m) across, the equivalent of a forty-five-lane highway.[20] The city had 109 districts, called quarters (*fang*). Each quarter had a wall around it; city officials closed the gates every night to enforce a strict curfew. To the north of the city, outside the rectangle, were the palace and various government offices, both civil and military. Only officials and members of the royal family could enter that district. Officials and courtiers tended to live in the eastern half of the city. Because they could afford more spacious houses with gardens, the eastern half of the city was less densely populated. Most ordinary people lived in the western half.

Two markets, known as the Eastern and Western Markets, each occupied an area about 0.4 square miles (1 sq km).[21] A road 400 feet (120 m) wide ran along the outside edge of the market to allow passage of people and vehicles; inside the market were more streets. Both markets, like the quarters of the city, were walled, and the gates were carefully guarded. No officials above the fifth rank (out of a total of nine) were allowed to enter, because the officials who served under Emperor Taizong (reigned 627–49) and who compiled the Tang Code, viewed commerce as polluting. The Tang Code made an exception for market officials, whom it charged with checking weights and setting prices every ten days.[22] Market supervisors issued certificates of ownership to the purchasers of livestock and slaves, who had to present these each time they crossed the border. These officials made sure that the markets opened only at noon and closed two hours before sundown.[23]

The Eastern Market tended to specialize in domestic goods, while the Western Market offered more foreign goods, many delivered by camel trains. Shops selling the same goods clustered together on narrow roads called *hang*. (Even today the Chinese word for expert is *neihang*, "inside the row," and for a layman *waihang*, "outside the row.") The Eastern Market had 220 different groups of shops selling different wares including Chinese brushes, iron goods, cloth, meat, wine, and printed materials. The Western Market offered foodstuffs as well as leather goods, like bridles and saddles, and jewelry and precious stones from all over Eurasia. The markets were packed with goods; a fire in 843 destroyed four thousand dwellings in twelve different rows of the Eastern Market.[24]

Visitors to the markets enjoyed restaurants, wine shops, food stands, and brothels, and traveling merchants could store their goods in warehouses, deposit their money in bank-like institutions, and stay at inns, some with as many as twenty rooms. The dispute between the Sogdian merchant Cao Rokhshan and the Chinese merchant Li Shaojin, discussed in chapter 3, illustrates how the Chinese

courts handled a dispute between Chinese and non-Chinese; they applied Chinese law. Tang-dynasty law stipulated that if foreigners from the same country committed a crime against each other, the law of their homeland would apply, but if foreigners of different nationalities were involved, then Chinese law would apply.[25] Recall that both men lived in the capital and traveled to the northwest on business.

Many travelers came to visit the Tang capital of Chang'an, home to some 960,000 people living in 300,000 households, according to the official history of the Tang.[26] In a population of one million people, the majority of the residents were Chinese, but a sizable foreign community lived in the city as well, concentrated around the Western Market.[27] Some foreigners settled in China as the result of treaties. In 631, after the Eastern Turks surrendered to the Tang, nearly ten thousand households were ordered to move to Chang'an, and many of these households were Sogdians in the service of the Turks.[28] When the Tang forces conquered different Central Asian kingdoms, they required their former rulers to send their sons to Chang'an as hostages, further swelling the numbers of foreigners in the city. Perhaps the most famous refugees were the descendants of the Sasanian emperors who fled Iran after the fall of their capital at Ctesiphon to Muslim forces in 651. The last Sasanian emperor, Yazdegerd III, died while in flight, but his son Peroz and grandson Narseh both moved permanently to the city.[29]

These immigrants brought their religious practices with them. At least five, maybe six, Zoroastrian temples stood in the city, four around the Western Market.[30] A single Christian church, affiliated with the Church of the East, was located just north of the Western Market. In modern Xi'an, the Forest of Steles (Beilin) Museum houses hundreds of stone tablets found all over China, the most famous of which, often referred to as the Nestorian stele, provides a history of Christianity under the Tang dynasty.[31]

According to this tablet, the first Christian to arrive in Chang'an was a man named Aluohan; dispatched by the patriarchate in Seleucia-Ctesiphon (in modern-day Iraq) in 635, he established the earliest outpost of the Church of the East in China.[32] The founding of this church coincided with a mass migration of Persians from their homeland in Iran, then under siege by Muslim armies, to China and other points east. Seventy names, in Syriac script with Chinese transcriptions, along with these individuals' positions in the church hierarchy, follow the main inscription. Some of the names, like Hope of Jesus, are unmistakably Christian, while others, such as Given by the Moon God Mah, are originally derived from Zoroastrianism but had become common names used throughout Mesopotamia. Each of the names has a Chinese transcription. It seems likely that most of the seventy signatories were foreign, not Chinese.



VESTIGES OF CHRISTIANITY IN THE TANG CAPITAL
Headed by a cross with four even sections, which was commonly used by the Church of the East, this text was carved onto a stone stele in 781. Discovered in 1625, the rubbing was shown by a Chinese official to Jesuit missionaries, who were overjoyed to learn that they were not the first Christian missionaries in China. They sent the rubbing to Europe, and by the 1670s both the Chinese and Syriac-language portions of the text had been translated. Cultural Relics Publishing House.

The Church of the East established churches in a few major Chinese cities: Chang'an, Luoyang, Guangzhou (Canton), and possibly in a few other places. Members of the Church of the East, largely Iranians and Sogdians, received the support of the Tang dynasty throughout the seventh and eighth centuries, but in 845 the Tang emperor issued a ban whose primary target was Buddhism but included Christianity as well. Buddhism survived, but the Church of the East did not.

No traces of this or any other religious institutions survive in today's Xi'an. In fact, the aboveground city of Xi'an contains remarkably few structures from Chang'an at its peak during the Tang. The visitor will look in vain for remnants of the glorious wide avenues. The wall one sees today is very large—so large that one

can ride a bicycle or drive a golf cart on top of it—but it dates to the Ming dynasty (1368–1644), not the Tang. The only Tang-dynasty structures still standing are two brick towers: the Big Goose Pagoda and the Small Goose Pagoda. Emperor Taizong built the Big Goose Pagoda to house the books Xuanzang brought back from India; Xuanzang supervised a team of translators there.

Only below ground, in tombs, can one hope to find a taste of the city's past glory. Unlike other sites on the Silk Road, Xi'an's climate is moister than that of the Taklamakan, so that buried paper eventually disintegrates. Still, thanks to the reuse of waste paper, a fascinating set of receipts from a pawnshop in Chang'an has survived in the arms of a figurine excavated in the Astana graveyard at Turfan. The documents mention several place-names unique to the Tang capital and so are almost certainly from Chang'an.

Craftsmen based in the Tang capital used discarded pawn slips to make the figurines that were subsequently placed in the joint grave of a man and his wife buried at Astana.[33] The husband died in 633, before the Chinese conquest of 640, and the wife more than fifty years later in 689. The figurine's fine brocade clothing and carefully worked head, pictured in color plate 8, also look as though they were produced in a workshop in the capital. The place-names mentioned in the documents have dated the pawnshop tickets to between 662, when the Guanyin Monastery changed its name, and 689, when the wife was buried in the joint tomb.

The discarded pawn tickets show how the ordinary inhabitants of Chang'an made ends meet during the seventh century. Each ticket follows the same format: item pawned, name of borrower, date (month and day, not year), the amount of money loaned, the amount of money paid back, the address and (sometimes) the age of the borrower. The slips list twenty-nine people by name yet give the occupations of only two individuals: one was a dyer and another made hairpins. When the pawned item was returned, the pawnshop employees cancelled the transaction by drawing a line (in the shape of a 7) across the ticket. Fifteen sheets of paper record fifty-four transactions (the last sixteen are incomplete), which are the earliest surviving pawnshop records found in China to date. In almost all of the transactions the borrower deposited an item of clothing (sometimes silk, sometimes simply cloth) or a piece of cloth (also used as a form of currency during the Tang) and received a certain number of coins, usually around a hundred, in exchange. Only two transactions involved goods besides clothing or cloth; one borrower put up a bronze mirror against a loan of seventy coins, while another presented four strings of pearls for 150 coins. The borrowers paid interest at a rate of 5 percent each month, which was within the limits set by Tang law (and far lower than the rates paid by borrowers in Turfan during the same period).

A second set of records, also preserved as part of a figurine, suggests that those frequenting the pawnshop near the Guanyin Monastery were relatively

well off. These list a total of 608 transactions, even small loans, made by Chang'an shops to city dwellers who paid with "medicine, cloth, beans, and wheat bran." One-fourth of these transactions were made by women, evidence that the female residents of the capital did leave their homes, even if Confucian ideals portrayed virtuous women as always staying inside.[34]

Another surprise find, this time from the capital itself, offers insight into those at the opposite end of the social spectrum, the wealthiest of the city's dwellers.[35] In 1970, during the Cultural Revolution, Xi'an archeologists uncovered two clay pots (25 inches, or 64 cm high) and one silver pot (10 inches, or 25 cm high) in Hejiacun, or Hejia Village, then in the southern suburbs. They were buried about 1 yard (.9 m) under the ground and 1 yard (.9 m) apart from each other. At the time, the authorities were building a detention center; a hostel for government officials now occupies the unmarked site. The three pots held over one thousand different items including gold and silver artifacts, precious gems and minerals, medicines, and an extraordinary coin collection. If the collection originally included more fragile items, like textiles or books, they have not survived. One of the largest hoards of buried treasure ever found in China, the Hejia Village collection certainly contains the most valuable and the most beautifully worked Silk Road artifacts.

No definitive evidence of the owner's identity survives. Almost everyone assumes that the hoard's owner intended to come back after some kind of disturbance—a rebellion? bandit attacks? a natural disaster?—but never did. The hoard was buried in a quarter approximately 0.6 miles (1 km) east of the Western Market and 2 miles (3 km) west of the Eastern Market. The best clue to the hoard's date is several silver biscuits with labels identifying them as tax payments. Before 780 the Tang dynasty required that its subjects pay three different types of taxes: *zu* (rent in grain), *yong* (corvée labor), and *diao* (cloth), but districts were allowed to substitute other goods. Four round silver biscuits, about 4 inches (10 cm) in diameter and weighing over 14 ounces (400 grams), are incised with crude characters that identify them as tax payments from two subprefectures in Guangdong Province. One is dated 722; three are dated 731. Inscriptions on these biscuits give their exact weights as well as the names of the officials who weighed them.

After the authorities received such biscuits, they melted them down into larger lumps, the largest weighing over 17 pounds (8 kg), which were labeled in black ink with the name of the storehouse where they were held—the Eastern Market Storehouse—and their weight and the official who weighed them.[36] Because central government officials melted down the biscuits they received from localities to make these larger lumps, it seems most likely that the hoard was buried not long after 731, the latest date on the biscuits. Many of the intricately worked gold and silver bowls in the collection bear similar labels, always

TABLE 5.1 HEJIACUN VILLAGE FIND CHART

Gold		Silver		Coins	
3	eating vessels	55	bowls	1	knife of *'Jimo'* from the kingdom of Qi
5	drinking cups	53	plates	1	shovel-shaped coin of Spring and Autumn Period
3	medicine containers	6	platters	4	early Han dynasty coins
2	washing basins	12	drinking cups	11	coins from the region of Wang Mang
10	hair pins	46	medicine containers	2	Six Dynasties coins
2	armlets	12	washing basins	1	*'Gaochang jili'* coin from Turfan (5th/6th century)
12	miniature dragons	1	lamp head (?)	1	Byzantine solidus of Heraclius (r. 610–640)
1	comb base	4	jugs	1	Sassanian drachm of Khusrau II (r. 590–628)
4388	grams gold foil	1	incense burner	5	Japanese silver coins with the legend *'Wado kaichin'* (708–15)
126	grams of gold dust	1	spherical censer	421	silver (including some bronze?) Tang dynasty coins with the legend *'Kaiyuan tongbao'*
		1	box		
		23	fasteners	30	gold *'Kaiyuan tongbao'* coins
		1	vessel with a spout		

Minerals and Glass				Medicines	
1	agate cup with gold bull head	55	white agate horse harnesses	1	block of yellow lead (litharge)
1	agate wine cup	53	white jade belt decorations	15	types of mineral powder, all in inscribed containers, including stalactite and gold
1	agate mortar	6	sapphires		
1	jade pestle	12	rubies		
1	white jade wine cup	46	green agates		
1	block of jade	12	topaz		

(*continued*)

TABLE 5.1 (CONTINUED)

Minerals and Glass				Medicines
1	crystal cup	1	white jade bracelet with gold decorations	
1	glass bowl	4	pieces of coral	
9	ceremonial hip belts	1	piece of amber	

Source: Preliminary site report published as 'Xi'an nanjiao Hejiacun faxian Tangdai jiaozang wenwu', *Wenwu* 1972:1, pp. 30–42. Reprinted with permission from *Orientations,* February 2003 issue, p. 15.

in black ink, giving their weight, an indication that they, too, were held in a government storehouse. Government officials apparently stored tax silver at three different stages in its life cycle: when it was first mined and submitted by various localities, after it had been melted into large lumps, and finally after it had been worked into gold and silver vessels.

Forty-six different silver vessels served as medicine containers that were labeled with both the weight and the grade of their contents: "stalactite of upper-upper grade" or "stalactite of medium-upper grade." Over 4.4 lbs (2 kg) of stalactite powder of different grades was buried in the hoard; Tang medical guides suggest daily doses of around 1.4 ounces, or 40 grams, for one or two hundred days to either calm the nerves or increase one's energy. The 4.4 ounces (126 grams) of gold dust probably had medicinal uses, as did a block of litharge, a lead oxide added to skin ointments to cure cuts and blemishes.[37]

Museum exhibits about the Silk Road or Tang-dynasty Chang'an often feature the Hejiacun gold and silver vessels, because they combine different elements of Iranian and Chinese art in extraordinarily pleasing ways.[38] In surviving paintings from the Sogdian city of Panjikent and Sogdian tomb panels found in China, Sogdian artists frequently mixed scenes showing Sogdian life, such as hunting or banquets with pictures of activities pursued by peoples, often Chinese, from other societies.

No one can tell by looking at a metal cup or container where it was made or who made it. Historians of technology tend to assume, though, that classic Sogdian shapes without Chinese motifs were made in Sogdiana and imported to China (if they were found in China), while any vessel whose shape departs from Sogdian prototypes was probably made in Chang'an, by Sogdian or Chinese craftsmen. By this measure, few of the Hejia Village vessels appear to be distinctly Sogdian: many more vessels have Chinese-style shapes.



A CUP FROM THE HEJIACUN VILLAGE HOARD
This gilt silver cup, measuring 2 inches (5.1 cm) tall, with a mouth 3.6 inches (9.1 cm) across, has several identifiable Sogdian characteristics: eight lobes, a thumb ring attached to a triangular medallion holding a deer, and a pearl border trim at its base. The exterior of the cup, like the murals on the northern wall of the Afrasiab house at Samarkand, alternates active scenes of men hunting, squarely in the tradition of Iranian royal art, with portraits of delicate women in Chinese gowns engaged in daily activities, like getting dressed or playing an instrument. Cultural Relics Publishing House.

The owner of the treasure separated the imported items from the other treasures and buried them in the silver jar with the handle; on the lid of the jar, he listed these goods.[39] A miniature rock-crystal bowl, only 1 inch (2.5 cm) tall and 3.8 inches (9.6 cm) across, has eight lobes, an identifying characteristic of Sogdian manufacture. Rock crystal occurs naturally but looks like glass when it is free of imperfections. The main constituent of both glass and rock crystal is silica, and one can make glass by melting rock crystal, but only at high temperatures—above 3,000 degrees Fahrenheit (1,700 degrees Centigrade), temperatures far too hot for any premodern workshop to achieve. In addition to the rock-crystal bowl, the hoard contained a glass vessel that must have been imported from the west, since Chinese craftsmen learned how to make opaque glass in ancient times but translucent glass only much later.[40] Historically, most glass was made from sand, limestone, and sodium carbonate.

Other imported items in the silver vase included gems not mined anywhere within the Tang empire: seven sapphires, two rubies, one topaz, and six agates. The largest, the topaz, weighed 119 grams (596 carats); the smallest (one of the

rubies) was just 2.5 grams (12.5 carats). Rubies and sapphires originated in Burma, Sri Lanka, Thailand, and Kashmir, India; topazes came as well from Burma and Sri Lanka as well as Japan and the Russian Urals. The unusual moss green color of the agates found at Hejia Village suggests an Indian source.[41] A beautiful rhyton drinking vessel crafted from carnelian, a brownish-red agate, was probably made in Gandhara or the Tocharistan region of Afghanistan.[42]

This composition of the hoard, with a few imported items and many more locally made vessels, fits the overall pattern of Silk Road trade. Relatively few goods traveled long distances overland; those that did were often precious gemstones that were small, light, and easy to carry. As Muslim armies conquered more territory, increasing numbers of migrants, including many skilled metal craftsmen, came to China and chose to settle in Chang'an, where many non-Chinese lived already. After Sogdian metalsmiths had migrated to China, they settled down and began to make vessels similar—but not identical—to those they had made in their homeland. As they learned more Chinese motifs and adjusted to a new clientele, they produced more hybrid items like the cup with its mixture of Chinese and Iranian elements.

A list of gifts that the emperor exchanged with An Lushan, before the Turco-Sogdian general rebelled, includes many items corresponding to objects in the Hejiacun hoard: Iranian-style silver ewers, parcel-gilt silver bowls, agate dishes, jade belts, coral, pearls, incense, and medicine in gold and silver boxes. In return the general gave Iranian-style bottles and plates made from silver and gold.[43] This list of gifts confirms that the vessels in the Hejiacun hoard came from the highest level of Chang'an society, the emperor and his top-ranking courtiers.

Of all the items buried at Hejia Village, the most difficult to explain is the collection of 478 coins. Six were definitely made outside of China: one silver coin minted during the reign of the Sasanian emperor Khusrau II (reigned 590–628) and five silver coins from Japan, dating to 708–15. There was a seventh coin, apparently a gold coin minted by the Byzantine emperor Heraclius (reigned 610–40), but, like so many of the Byzantine coins found in China, it is an imitation made in China, not a genuine Byzantine coin. Equally unusual was a selection of twenty historic Chinese coins. The earliest, dating to about 500 BCE, were examples of China's first currency, shaped like a shovel and a knife. Also included were coins from the Han dynasty (206 BCE–220 CE) and the centuries of disunity before the Tang unification. The final group of coins was the largest: 451 stamped with the Kaiyuan reign period (713–41). The Kaiyuan coins included bronze examples, which circulated widely at the time, as well as silver and gold coins, apparently specially made for the emperor to give out at parties (one such party occurred in 713, according to the official histories).[44] The composition of the coin collection, including foreign-made,

historic, and contemporary examples, has prompted some to wonder if it belonged to a private collector.[45]

How can we best explain the varied composition of the Hejia Village hoard? Although some items, like the medicinal powder and the coin collection, may seem as though they belonged to an individual, more of the collection—particularly the tax biscuits—looks as though it came from a government storehouse. All the items labeled with their weight and the name of the weighing official also point to an official storeroom. The coins may have belonged to a private coin collector, but no other collections from the Tang have been found; they could also have been kept by the section of the government that minted coins as a kind of reference collection. In premodern China, the line between individual and government property was not as sharp as in modern societies. Perhaps an official who worked in the mint added a few of his own possessions to the government property at the time of burial.

When would someone in Chang'an have been most likely to bury such an extraordinary collection of treasures? The first great rebellion that shattered the steady peace of the first century and a half of Tang rule occurred in 755, when An Lushan (or An Rokhshan) led a military uprising against the Tang emperor Xuanzong. After conquering Luoyang, An Lushan and the rebels took Chang'an in 755, forcing the emperor to flee the capital with his beautiful consort Yang Guifei. En route to Sichuan, the imperial guard threatened to mutiny unless the emperor killed Yang Guifei, and the emperor gave the order to strangle her. He then relinquished the throne in favor of his son.

The new emperor did not have enough troops to defeat the rebels and was forced to cede the power to tax to regional governors, who provided him with the troops he needed. For the next seven years, the war between the rebels and the Tang forces continued. Even though An Lushan was assassinated in 757 and his second-in-command was also assassinated in 761, the rebels maintained a strong presence until the Tang emperor asked the help of the Uighur kaghan, whose troops defeated the rebel army in 763.[46] The Uighurs were allowed to sack the Tang capital as a reward for their services, and they devastated the city.

When the Tang forces finally regained control of the empire, they took measures against the Sogdians, whom they blamed for the rebellion. They replaced the character "An," meaning "peace," in all the names of gates and streets in the capital; many people, both Sogdian and not, whose family name was An, adopted new surnames.[47] One account of the rebellion recounts that the general Gao Juren, himself ethnically Korean, who wrested control of Beijing from the rebels "ordered that those who killed *hu* [Iranians, most likely Sogdians] would be richly rewarded. As a result, the *jiehu* [a sub-set of the *hu* that An Lushan belonged to, possibly those living in north China] were completely

exterminated. Small children were tossed in the air and caught on lances. Those who had big noses like the Sogdians and those who were killed by mistake for this reason were extremely numerous."[48]

The targeting of Sogdians marked a new and ugly chapter in the history of the Silk Road. Previous dynasties had sometimes ordered the closing of monasteries and the forced laicization of monks and nuns, but no earlier ruler had ever targeted a minority group within the larger Chinese population in this way. Pogrom-like attacks on Sogdians did not occur everywhere Sogdians lived, but in Chang'an a new climate of intolerance seems to have set in. Even so, many foreigners living in Chang'an decided to stay within China, with many relocating to the area south of Beijing in modern Hebei Province, rather than risk returning to Islamified areas of Sogdiana and Central Asia.

The final defeat of the rebels did not bring peace to the beleaguered capital. In late 763 an army from the newly united Tibetan Empire attacked Chang'an and pillaged the city for two weeks before retreating. They continued to do so for the next twenty years. The Tang armies were powerless against the forces of the Tibetans, who, along with the Uighurs, succeeded the Tang as Asia's leading military power for more than a century.

When the Tibetans gained control of Gansu in the 780s and Kucha in the 790s, the Tang saw its revenues decline even further. In 787, in response to the fall of Gansu Province, the prime minister Li Mi proposed a budget-cutting measure: slashing the subsidies for all foreign envoys resident in the capital. He was "aware that many of the Central Asians were long-term residents, some having been in the capital for more than forty years, that they had all married, purchased land and housing and made other investments on which they earned interest, and that they had no intention of ever returning to their homelands."[49] The minister put the number of foreign envoys, most of them Sogdian, at four thousand, a surprisingly high figure given that many foreigners would have fled or concealed their identity after the An Lushan rebellion.

Fictional tales document the lives of these Sogdians, particularly rich merchants, who remained in Chang'an after 763. A new genre of short story, the "wonder tale," peaked in popularity in the early ninth century.[50] Different authors describe the Sogdians as possessing the same traits: excessive generosity coupled with an uncanny ability to judge goods, especially jewels. In exile from their homeland, many were born to noble families but forced, in these narratives, to take menial jobs so that they could survive in China.

In one story set in Chang'an in the years after the An Lushan rebellion,[51] a young man from a wealthy Chinese family finds an unusual rock, "half ocean-colored, half red, with deep stripes," on the beach. He chances upon the annual gathering of some thirty foreign merchants: "The person with the most valuable

treasures wears a hat and sits in the place of honor; the others sit in ranks below him." The youth watches as they compare their riches—one merchant has four beautiful pearls, one more than an inch across. Others present their wares, mostly pearls, and then the youth displays his stone to the assembled merchants, who promptly stand up and escort him to the place of honor. When he asks for one million strings, they retort, "Why are you insulting this treasure of ours?" and insist on paying ten million. It turns out that the jewel is a national treasure that has been lost for over thirty years; they call it the "treasure mother," because their king places it on the shore, prays to it in the evening, and when he returns the next morning, he finds the precious stones that have surrounded it of their own accord. The jewel's magic powers fulfill the genre's promise of marvels, but the setting is realistic: it is entirely plausible that thirty or so Sogdian merchants would gather annually in the Tang capital.

Stereotypically wealthy Iranian merchants also appear in a different literary genre, model legal decisions. During the Tang dynasty, and particularly after 755, increasing numbers of young men sat the civil service examinations, and they proved ready consumers for this type of literature. Not based on actual legal cases, these model decisions treated hypothetical situations that allowed authors to display their reasoning skills.

One model decision tells of two Sogdian brothers who live in Chang'an.[52] One is so wealthy that his garden, pond, house, furniture, and male and female servants "rival those of marquises and princes." His brother, on the other hand, is so poor that he is unable to repay the loan of a garment from another wealthy Sogdian merchant. That merchant takes the wealthy brother to court for refusing to pay the poor brother's loan, and the prefect rules that the wealthy brother must give some livestock to the younger brother so that he does not die of starvation.

The marvel tales and the model cases document the existence of a powerful stereotype: Tang-dynasty authors viewed Sogdian merchants as tremendously wealthy because of the jewel trade. Sogdian merchants did indeed deal in jewels and gemstones, which had the twin advantages of being both valuable and light. But the existence of a stereotype does not make it true: we cannot conclude that the Silk Road trade was so prosperous that it enriched thousands of Sogdians living in Chang'an. Of the thousands of Sogdians who settled in the cities of Tang-dynasty China, merchants constituted only a minority.[53] Emissaries, military dependents, refugees, farmers, metalsmiths, and soldiers also came in large numbers.

In 843 the emperor gave voice to the persisting anti-foreign sentiment in the capital when he banned Manichaeism, and two years later in 845 forbade the practice of Buddhism, Zoroastrianism, and Christianity. His stated goal was to increase the amount of money available for minting coins, so he ordered that

statues and bells be melted down. In addition, the authorities confiscated the property of all but a handful of Buddhist monasteries in Chang'an and Luoyang. When the emperor died in 847 his successor lifted the ban on Buddhism but not on the other religions.

These measures came at a time when the dynasty was ceding large chunks of territory in the northwest to newly powerful regional leaders, often former military commanders who controlled their own armies and who gradually refused to pay taxes to the ruling dynasty. After the withdrawal of Chinese troops from the Taklamakan oasis towns in the 750s, the land routes gradually declined, while sea travel gained primacy.[54] Though perilous, sea travel had occurred in earlier centuries, and many of those traveling by boat began their journeys at Chang'an.

Since ancient times the residents of Southeast Asia had voyaged by boat in the South China Sea and the western Pacific, and over time they linked different coastal routes together to form longer routes. By at least the first century of the Common Era sailors had learned both how to harness the monsoon winds and how to navigate the straits of Malacca so that they could sail all the way from China to India, but they had to stop for several months in Srivijaya (modern-day Palembang, on the island of Sumatra in Indonesia) to wait for the winds to shift.[55]

The monk Faxian (active 350–414) wrote vividly about the difficulties of sea travel between India and China. Living more than two centuries before Xuanzang, he had the same motivation for going to India: to study texts in the original that were not available in China. On the outward leg, he proceeded overland from Chang'an through Khotan and then to India. After studying for more than six years in the major Buddhist centers on the Ganges River, he caught a boat to Sri Lanka at the port of Tamluk, on the mouth of Hoogly River, south of Calcutta in West Bengal.[56]

The two-week voyage to Sri Lanka turned out to be the only uneventful leg of his long sea voyage. In Sri Lanka Faxian visited an image of the Buddha made from jade and other precious substances that stood over 22 feet (6.6 meters) tall. While he was in the temple, a merchant, probably Chinese, presented a white silk fan as a donation. Suddenly, in a rare personal note, Faxian admits to being overcome with homesickness and weeping.[57] Faxian stayed for two more years in Sri Lanka, where he noted the presence of "many scholars, venerable monks, sabao and merchants."[58] As in Sogdian Ancient Letter 5, Sogdians used the term sabao to indicate the leaders of their communities, and here Faxian contrasts the Sogdian sabao with Chinese merchants.

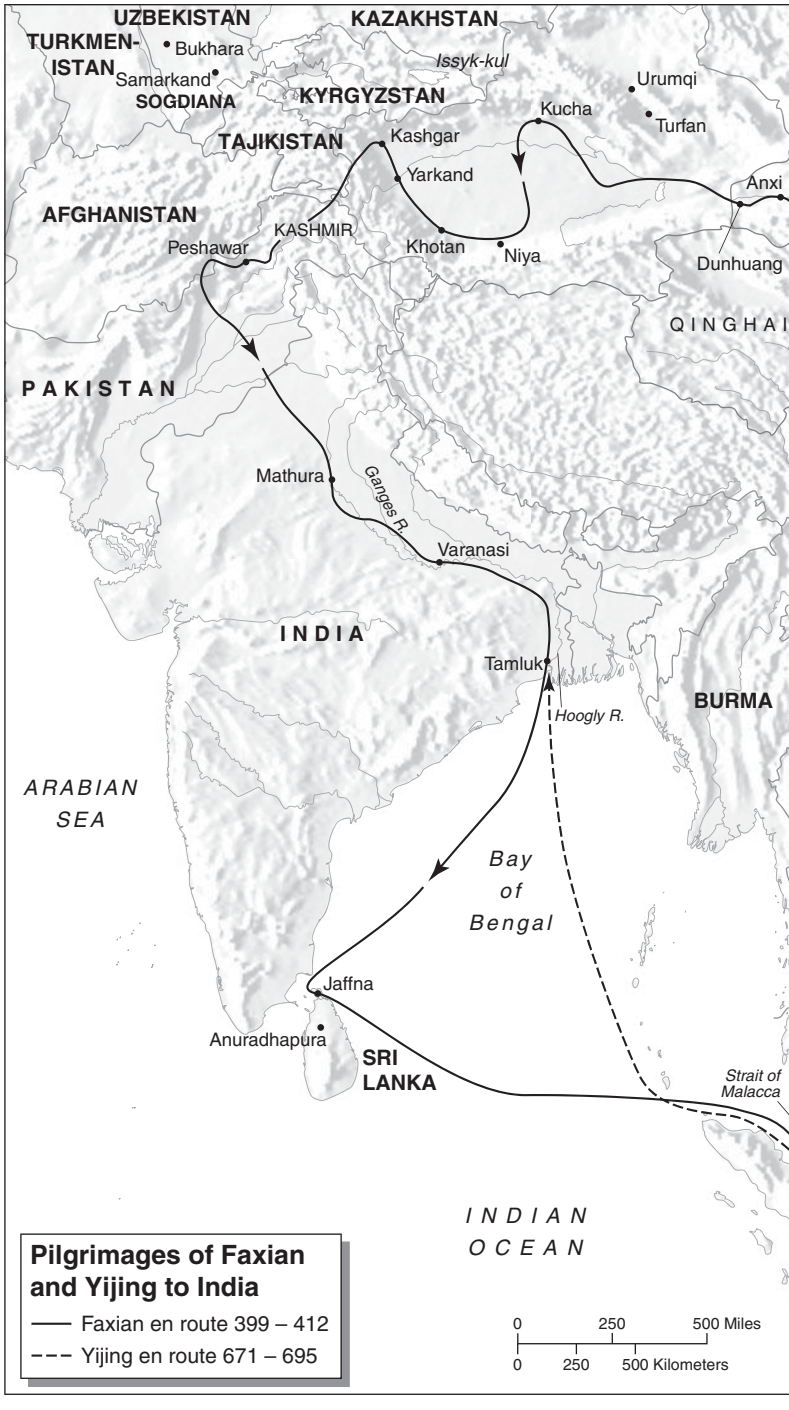
Faxian does not give the reasons for his decision to take the sea, and not the overland, route to China, but for those departing from either Tamluk or

Sri Lanka, the sea route was faster and cheaper. In Sumatra he found passage on a "large merchant boat" carrying two hundred people, which was tied to a smaller boat intended for use as a lifeboat.[59] After three days, a great wind—perhaps a typhoon—rose up and did not subside for thirteen days. Those in the smaller boat cut the line connecting them to the larger boat. The merchants, desperate to save their lives in the leaking larger boat, pitched much of their cargo overboard, but Faxian refused to part with the Buddhist texts he had so painstakingly collected. He prayed to the bodhisattva Guanyin, the Buddhist goddess of mercy, for protection, and his account reports that she answered his prayer. When the storm subsided, the larger boat landed on an island where the crew was able to patch the leak and proceed to Sumatra.

Faxian stayed in Sumatra for five months before taking a different ship, about as big as the first, which could carry two hundred people on their way to Guangzhou, along with fifty days' worth of provisions. This leg of the journey proved to be even more perilous than the trip from Sri Lanka to Sumatra. After more than a month on the water, a "black wind and torrential rain" rose up. Faxian again prayed to Guanyin. The Indian passengers had a different response: blaming the Chinese monk for the storm, they decided to leave him alone on an island and continue on without him. Faxian calls these Indian passengers "Brahmans," the general Chinese term for all Indians. The person who paid for his passage interceded on the monk's behalf and threatened that the Chinese ruler, himself a Buddhist, would punish the passengers if they abandoned the monk. Hesitating, the Indians could not bring themselves to abandon Faxian and so permitted him to continue his journey.

The persistently cloudy skies prevented the ship's navigators from determining the right course. Since they did not use a compass, they could only set their course by examining the position of the sun, moon, and stars. When it rained or was cloudy, they had no way to determine their location. They knew that the trip to China should take fifty days, but they simply could not get their bearings. The boat continued to sail in the ocean, its food and water supplies fast dwindling. After seventy days at sea—twenty more than planned—the crew distributed two Chinese pints of water to each passenger and began to cook with seawater. The ship shifted its course northwest in search of land. After eleven more days, it made landfall.

On the basis of the plants they saw on shore, the passengers concluded that they were somewhere in China and sent Faxian to ask where. When he returned to the ship, he informed them that they had arrived at the southern shore of the Shandong Peninsula, about one thousand miles (1,600 km) north of their original destination of Guangzhou. Faxian's trip vividly illustrates the perils of sea


UZBEKISTAN
KAZAKHSTAN
TURKMEN-
ISTAN
Bukhara
Issyk-kul
Samarkand
SOGDIANA
KYRGYZSTAN
Urumqi
Kucha
Turfan
TAJIKISTAN
Kashgar
Yarkand
Anxi
AFGHANISTAN
KASHMIR
Peshawar
Khotan
Niya
Dunhuang
QINGHAI
PAKISTAN
Mathura
Ganges R.
Varanasi
INDIA
Tamluk
BURMA
Hoogly R.
ARABIAN
SEA
Bay
of
Bengal
Jaffna
Anuradhapura
SRI
LANKA
Strait of
Malacca
INDIAN
OCEAN
Pilgrimages of Faxian and Yijing to India
Faxian en route 399 – 412
Yijing en route 671 – 695
0
250
500 Miles
0
250
500 Kilometers


RUSSIA
MONGOLIA
NINGXIA
Yellow R.
Beijing
Taiyuan
SILLA
(KOREA)
JAPAN
Wuwei
(Liangzhou)
SHAANXI
SHANXI
SHANDONG
YELLOW
SEA
GANSU
Guyuan
Tongzhou
Luoyang
JIANGSU
Yangzhou
Qinzhou
HENAN
Wei R.
Xi'an
(Chang'an)
SICHUAN
Yangzi R.
CHINA
EAST
CHINA
SEA
GUANGDONG
Canton (Guangzhou)
PACIFIC
OCEAN
SOUTH
CHINA
SEA
THAILAND
SUMATRA
INDONESIA
Srivijaya
(Palembang)

travel before 1000, approximately the time the Chinese began to use compasses while on shipboard. (They had been using them on land for more than a thousand years.)[60] Even with all its perils, Faxian's sea journey was three years shorter than the outbound overland leg, which had taken him six years.

In the late seventh century, when the Buddhist monk Yijing (635–713) traveled to India to seek original Buddhist texts, he also sailed there and back by ship. Like Faxian, he started his trip in Chang'an. He then traveled to the port city of Yangzhou in modern-day Jiangsu. There he met an imperial envoy who paid for his passage to Guangzhou. In Guangzhou he arranged with the captain of a "Persian ship" to travel to Palembang on the island of Sumatra. (The ship may have had a Persian crew or captain, or it may simply have been Persian in style.)

Departing in late 671, the two men arrived in Palembang after less than twenty days. Yijing describes constellations in the sky, a clue that Chinese sailors were still navigating by the stars and did not use the compass. After six months of studying Sanskrit in Palembang, Yijing then made his way by boat along the northern edge of the island of Sumatra, crossed the Indian Ocean without stopping at Sri Lanka, and arrived at the port of Tamluk, near modern Calcutta, early in 673, slightly more than a year after his departure from China.

Yijing took the same route back to Palembang, where he planned to stay to record more texts. In 689 he wrote a letter to supporters in China asking for paper, ink, and money to pay scribes to write these texts. He boarded a ship in port so that he could mail the letter, but "just at that time the merchant found the wind favorable, and raised the sails high," carrying the reluctant Yijing all the way back to Guangzhou.[61] The suddenness of his trip testifies to its frequency. Yijing said that he went to Guangzhou simply because of the workings of karma, but his experience shows how developed sea travel had become since 400 when Faxian traveled. The express boats that sailed from Palembang to Guangzhou stopped for no one—not even someone who had boarded the ship in error.

On his arrival in Guangzhou, Yijing announced his intent to return to Palembang. His friends introduced him to another monk who wanted to study in India, and, in the same year that he arrived, after the monsoon winds had shifted, the two men went back to the island to retrieve the books Yijing had left behind. Yijing stayed there until 695, when he finally came home to China, again by boat.

The trip between Palembang and Guangzhou had become so routine that Yijing managed it three times in his lifetime, and others plied the route too. After Yijing returned to China he wrote a collective biography of fifty-six monks who had traveled to India. Forty-seven were Chinese, one was Sogdian,

and eight were from the Korean kingdom of Silla. Of the fifty-six, twenty-one traveled overland and thirty traveled by sea. Yijing's sample may exaggerate the size of the sea trade, since he recorded the names of monks that he learned about during his travels on the sea route and during the months he stayed at Palembang, but even so his survey suggests the popularity of sea travel in the late 600s.

The sea routes continued to grow in importance. Many of those sailing to Chinese ports in the ninth century were Arabs who came from the ports of Iraq, particularly Basra; the trip took around five months.[62] One early description of China written in Arabic dates to 851; the anonymous author gathered testimony from people who had personally visited China.[63] He reports that the Chinese authorities at the port of Guangzhou, the main port of entry for those coming from Iraq, seized the cargo of any foreign merchant, collected a 30 percent tax, and then returned the goods after six months. The Chinese merchants bought ivory, frankincense, cast copper, and tortoise shells, and they paid in bronze coins; in exchange they offered "gold, silver, pearls, silk, and rich stuffs in great abundance," as well as "an excellent kind of cohesive green clay with which they make cups as fine as phials in which the light of water is seen," that is, porcelain.[64] Since the authorities required the same travel passes that they did of those entering China overland, all merchants had to report their exact itineraries before they could enter China. The author is remarkably positive about China. He portrays the Chinese legal system as fair, even to foreigners, and he describes the bankruptcy law of the Chinese in great detail.

In 916 a geographer named Abu Zayd copied this account in full and then wrote a sequel to it. Overall, he finds the earlier account accurate, and he mentions a "man of undoubted credit" who helped him make corrections. This informant, he writes, "told us also that since those days [the years before 851] the affairs of China had put on quite another face; and since much is related, to show the reason why the voyages to China are interrupted, and how the country has been ruined, many customs abolished, and the empire divided." He elaborates: an 877 uprising in Guangzhou, led by a former examination candidate named Huang Chao, led to the deaths "in addition to the Chinese [of] one hundred and twenty thousand people, Muslims, Christians, Jews and Zoroastrians who had sought refuge in the city."[65] Many doubt the accuracy of this figure: another Arabic source reports that 200,000 perished in Guangzhou, while Chinese sources give no specifics at all.[66] Whatever the exact death toll, the Huang Chao rebels dealt a severe blow to both Guangzhou and the sea trade.

After looting Guangzhou, the rebels arrived in Chang'an early in 881, burned down the Western Market, seized the palace, and sacked the city. Government

armies succeeded in driving the rebels out of the city, which they then proceeded to loot themselves. The emperor was reduced to a mere figurehead. The poet Wei Zhuang described the city after the rebels had left:

> Chang'an lies in mournful stillness: what does it now contain?
> —Ruined markets and desolate streets, in which ears of wheat are sprouting.
> Fuel-gatherers have hacked down every flowering plant in the Apricot Gardens,
> Builders of barricades have destroyed the willows along the Imperial Canal.
> All the gaily-colored chariots with their ornamented wheels are scattered and gone.
> Of the stately mansions with their vermilion gates less than half remain.
> The Hanyuan Hall is the haunt of foxes and hares.
> The approach to the Flower-calyx Belvedere is a mass of brambles and thorns.
> All the pomp and magnificence of the older days are buried and passed away;
> Only a dreary waste meets the eye; the old familiar objects are no more.
> The Inner Treasury is burnt down, its tapestries and embroideries a heap of ashes;
> All along the Street of Heaven one treads on the bones of State officials.[67]

Chang'an remained the capital for twenty more years, but then in 904 the general who ruled behind the fiction of the Tang dynasty ordered the emperor's servants killed and the imperial palace dismantled and floated down the Wei River to Luoyang. In 907 he killed the last Tang emperor, seized power outright, and founded a new dynasty. The once-glorious Tang capital lay in ruins, never to recover. The severing of the trade routes to the capital isolated the oases of the northwest, and the Silk Road trade entered a new, quieter era.